

INSEAD

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT THE SCHOOL

"The Business School for the World" is how INSEAD positions itself, and it lives up to the promise with 80+ nationalities on its MBA program, and an equally diverse faculty and alumni network. International diversity has been part of the school's DNA since its inception, over 50 years ago, when it pioneered the one-year MBA. Today the school has the largest MBA program in the world, with more than 1,000 students per year, spread across two intakes (one class starts in January and another in September) and across two campuses (Fontainebleau, a small town 70km from Paris, and in Singapore). MBAs also have the option of taking electives on the school's Abu Dhabi campus, and exchange to top US schools. The school is also proud of providing an international platform for recruitment, with graduates taking up positions in over 50 countries around the world each year.

The program is very much a General Management degree, but has a strong elective offering, enabling students to deepen their knowledge in a wide range of areas. Entrepreneurship is a particularly popular area, with 80% of students taking at least one entrepreneurship elective.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

*General Management, Entrepreneurship, Finance, Strategy, Impact
Investing, Energy, Strategy*

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	2	-	4	-	-	1	3	2
Financial Times	2	2	2	-	-	1	1	1
Forbes	-	2	-	-	-	2	-	2
The Economist	6	7	4	-	-	4	4	4

CLASS OF 2021 ADMISSIONS

Number of Applicants	-	Avg Age	28
MBA Class Size	~1000	Avg GMAT	706
Admissions selectivity	-	Avg GPA	-
Yield	38%	% International	91%
Total Tuition	€89,000	% Women	35%

POST-MBA CAREERS (CLASSES OF 2019)

Consulting	35%
Technology, Media & Telecomms	23%
Corporate Sectors	17%
Finance	11%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

McKinsey, BCG, Bain & Co., Accenture, Kearney, Amazon, Strategy&, Restaurant Brands International, Uber, Microsoft

AVERAGE BASE SALARY: US\$105,900

EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS: 92%

**Rankings are relative to other European business schools that appeared in at least three of the four major media rankings. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.*



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR INSEAD APPLICATION

BY CAROLINE DIARTE EDWARDS

Former Director of Admissions, Marketing and Financial Aid for the INSEAD MBA program, where she admitted over 7,000 students, Caroline Diarte Edwards has extensive expertise in the business school sector. A leader among admissions industry experts, Caroline is regularly featured in the Financial Times, the Wall Street Journal, Business Week, CNN, the Economist, the Times of London, China Economic Review, Spiegel, and The New York Times. Caroline holds an MBA from INSEAD and is a graduate of the University of Cambridge.



Demonstrate you possess qualities – openness, flexibility, curiosity about other cultures, interpersonal skills, and maturity – that will allow you to fit well in an incredibly diverse environment.

1

SHOWCASE YOUR INTERNATIONAL MINDSET

INSEAD takes great pride in the international diversity of its MBA program: both as regards to the range of nationalities represented, and the international experience of the students. But not everyone at INSEAD has a lot of international experience. Typically, those who gain admission without much experience beyond their own borders are from emerging markets (they may not have had financial means to travel). If you've had limited international experience it will be imperative that you demonstrate that you possess qualities – openness, flexibility, curiosity about other cultures, interpersonal skills, and maturity – that will allow you to fit well in an incredibly diverse environment. You'll also need to demonstrate that joining such an international community will be highly relevant to your future career plans. Someone who has never travelled abroad, and who has no interest in business beyond his or her own national border should think twice before applying.

KNOW THAT YOU MAY BE ASKED TO START ON YOUR 2ND CHOICE CAMPUS

2

The Admissions Committee takes decisions blind of campus choice – i.e. they cannot see whether you have applied to Fontainebleau or Singapore. So the chances are equal. However this does mean that not all campus preferences can be accommodated – typically, a handful of students will be asked to start on the campus that was not their stated preference, to enable the school to achieve the right class size and a similarly diverse class across campuses.

3

YOUR GMAT BREAKDOWN MATTERS MORE THAN YOUR OVERALL SCORE

The average GMAT at INSEAD is 709; the range is typically around 600 to 800. INSEAD advises candidates to target the 75th percentile on both the verbal and the quant; they look more at this breakdown than at the total score. If you get less than 70th percentile on either part of the test, you better have a very strong academic track record, and/or have a profile that the school loves. So INSEAD is perhaps not as flexible as some top schools as regards the GMAT - this is largely because it is a one year program, so the pace is fast, and the school really needs to be sure you have the academic smarts to keep up. And although many love to hate the GMAT, it is actually a fairly good predictor of academic performance on the INSEAD program.

DIFFERENTIATE, DIFFERENTIATE, DIFFERENTIATE

4

There are some profiles that pour in to the INSEAD admissions office by the hundreds: for example, management consultants based in Europe, French Engineers or Indian IT professionals. Whilst INSEAD has no hard and fast quota, they also want to create a diverse class, so in reality, the competition can be tougher for some than for others. If you have a common profile, then you need to be strong across all elements of the application, including your academic profile, your professional track record, your international experience, and your activities and achievements outside of work or study. Try to find some element to your profile that can differentiate you: e.g. a multicultural background, an entrepreneurial side interest, etc.

5

WANT CHANGE CAREERS? SHOW THAT YOU'VE DONE YOUR HOMEWORK

Most INSEAD students are making some significant change in their career. The MBA program measures change across three dimensions: industry, function and country. In fact, typically about 80% make a change on one of these dimensions, and about 25% make a change on all three dimensions. If you are planning a pretty dramatic career change, you could be well advised to join the January intake, so that you can take an internship in July and August (the September entry does not have an internship option).

Having said that, the stats quoted above do not vary much between the January or September entries, so if you are targeting a September start, you can still count on a big change being possible. And while many INSEAD students end up changing their minds about their future plans during the year, be warned that a 10-month program does not give you a lot of time for navel gazing and mulling over infinite options. You need to be ready to make decisions about your future direction fairly quickly, and you also need to be able to juggle an intensive academic schedule with an ongoing and regular investment of time in your job search.

ESSAY ANALYSIS

INSEAD guides you to showcase, in relative depth, the career choices you've made leading up to this point, and your post-MBA career vision, as well as the unique personal qualities and experiences that will make you a valuable addition to the class.



CAREER ESSAY 1. Briefly summarize your current (or most recent) job, including the nature of work, major responsibilities, and where relevant, employees under your supervision, size of budget, clients/products and results achieved. (200 words, maximum)

This question is intended to give the reader a snapshot of where you are right now in your career. Don't overthink it, as you will have ample space in later essays (and other elements of your application) to drill down on the details of your major accomplishments. In this question, be sure to mention your title, organization, location and major responsibilities. Do feel free to list a couple accomplishments if space allows, though don't repeat the accomplishment you use in your accomplishment essay later in the application. If relevant, also include leadership and teamwork, and any international projects or work that has an international scope. Quantify as much as possible throughout.

Try not to get too technical; don't use industry jargon and keep your language in layman's terms as your readers may not be familiar with your industry or function.

CAREER ESSAY 2. What would be your next step in terms of position if you were to remain in the same company? (200 words max)

Job titles can vary wildly from industry to industry, and even company to company within the same industry. This question aims to give the reader a fuller understanding of where you sit in your company hierarchy and your career trajectory where you are. It's best to be as straightforward

with your answer as possible. Say what your next promotion or title would like to be and list any new responsibilities you may have and /or management of others under this new role. This answer can often be quite short, about 100 words.

Job titles can vary wildly from industry to industry, and even company to company within the same industry. This question aims to give the reader a fuller understanding of where you sit in your company hierarchy and your career trajectory where you are. It's best to be as straightforward with your answer as possible. Say what your next promotion or title would be like to be and list any new responsibilities you may have and /or management of others under this new role. This answer can often be quite short, about 100 words.

CAREER ESSAY 3. Please give a full description of your career since graduating from university. Describe your career path with the rationale behind your choices. (300 words max)

Your CV shows the positions you've had, but this essay allows you go deeper, giving insight into why you made the choices you did. This is a critical part of your overall narrative as an applicant, so do be sure to give it the attention it deserves. A wonderful feature of this essay is that it allows you to explain the value-add of career choices that may not be obvious from a read of your CV. For example, a past client turned down an offer from Bain & Co to work at a boutique consulting firm without wide scale brand recognition because it allowed him to work directly with CEOs and other C-level clients from day one. Another took a cut in salary to gain critical in-market international experience. Another passed up a promotion, opting instead for a lateral move that would better position her in the long-term.

Approach this essay in chronological order, starting with your first role after university until present day. Remember that you will have space to detail your accomplishments in your CV and in a later essay. By all means, show your career progression and promotions at each organization, and if you have room for a major accomplishment or two you can add that, too. But, particularly if you've had extensive career experience or held several different roles in the time you've worked, you'll want to save the word count for the main focus of this essay, which is the rationale behind your choices.

our CV shows the positions you've had, but this essay allows you go deeper, giving insight into *why* you made the choices you did. This is a critical part of your overall narrative as an applicant, so do be sure to give it the attention it deserves. A wonderful feature of this essay is that it allows you to explain the value-add of career choices that may not be obvious from a read of your CV. For example, a past client turned down an offer from Bain & Co to work at a boutique consulting firm without wide scale brand recognition because it allowed him to work directly with CEOs and other C-level clients from day one. Another took a cut in salary to gain critical in-market international experience. Another passed up a promotion, opting instead for a lateral move that would better position her in the long-term.

Approach this essay in chronological order, starting with your first role after university until present day. Remember that you will have space to detail your accomplishments in your CV and in a later essay. By all means, show your career progression and promotions at each organization, and if you have room for a major accomplishment or two you can add that, too. But, particularly if you've had extensive career experience or held several different roles in the time you've worked, you'll want to save the word count for the main focus of this essay, which is the rationale behind your choices.

CAREER ESSAY 4. Discuss your short and long term career aspirations with an MBA from INSEAD. (100 words max)

With only 100 words to work with, you'll need to be as straightforward as possible in how you answer this question. What is your immediate post-MBA career goal, where do you see yourself in 10 - 15 years, and what is the route between the two?

Try to get as specific as possible (even though it's hard to know) with sample company names and ideas of certain titles of the job you seek. You can even include geographic location. Ideally, try to include one or two sentences about why you are passionate about this career trajectory.

CAREER ESSAY 5. (Optional) If you are currently not working or if you plan to leave your current employer more than 2 months before the programme starts, please explain your activities and occupations between leaving your job and the start of the programme. (No word limit but we suggest 300 max)

Only complete this essay if it adds value to your narrative, and if you do have a plan. Given the length of the INSEAD application, it's better to leave the optional essay blank rather than to fill the space with nonessential info.

However, this could be an opportunity to address gaps or weaknesses in your profile, such as if you are light on extracurriculars or volunteering. Perhaps you can take some time before the start of the program to strengthen this weakness, such as volunteering in X country to help Y organization. Better still, lay out a plan that shows you've already taken the initiative and thought through the details. For example, you have reached out to X organization and have agreed to a two-month pro-bono project in Y country, during which you will work on Z problem with a goal to deliver A, B and C results.

MOTIVATION ESSAY 1. Give a candid description of yourself, stressing the personal characteristics you feel to be your strengths and weaknesses and the main factors which have influenced your personal development, giving examples when necessary. (500 words MAX)

Through this question, the committee is seeking to understand both who you are as a person – your unique characteristics, motivations and values – and the major life events and people who have helped shape you into the person you are today. It requires a great degree of self-awareness and cannot be answered well without some deep introspection. Clients say they get an enormous amount of value working with a coach on answering this question that extends well beyond their business school applications.

In answering this question, favor depth over breadth. It's best to structure your answer around 3 - 5 main themes, weaving in the story of your background and upbringing, and intertwining your strengths and weaknesses. You can bring in examples from your professional life, but keep in mind that your professional story is well told throughout a lot of other aspects of your application. This is an opportunity to bring the Admissions Committee in on your personal story, and that is where the focus should be. Do not be tempted to gloss over your weaknesses or try to position your weaknesses as strengths. The seasoned admissions reader will see right through this, and it signals a lack of self-awareness and maturity in discerning areas you still need to improve.

MOTIVATION ESSAY 2. Describe the achievement of which you are most proud and explain why. In addition, describe a situation where you failed. How did these experiences impact your relationships with others? Comment on what you learned. (400 words MAX)

You'll want to be sure to use at least one professional example in this essay. It will vary from applicant to applicant, but if you've been able to tell your personal story well in the first motivation essay then in most cases it's best to use a professional example for the accomplishment in this essay. The failure can work well as either a professional or personal example.

As with the first motivation essay, the committee will be looking for you to demonstrate your self-awareness here. For the accomplishment, you'll need to detail not just what you achieved, but also what you had to overcome to do so, what resources you had to draw upon to make it

happen, and why it made you proud. To optimize your impact with the reader, illustrate how you made a positive impact on the organization by quantifying the results.

For the failure, choose something that you were accountable for – a 'mistake' or an oversight you made at work (perhaps earlier on in your career) and then conclude with what you learned from the experience. It may seem counterintuitive but it is often better to have an example of a big failure rather than a small failure. Big failures can demonstrate that you are a risk taker and have learned a great deal from your experiences.

In both cases, don't forget to detail how these experiences have impacted your relationships with others. Put another way, what soft skills did you hone through these experiences that will make you a better addition to your study team and INSEAD class?

MOTIVATION ESSAY 3. Describe all types of extra-professional activities in which you have been or are still involved for a significant amount of time (clubs, sports, music, arts, politics, etc). How are you enriched by these activities? (300 words MAX)

This is your opportunity to show the Admissions Committee that you're a well-rounded person, with interests that extend beyond your professional life. With only 300 words for this essay, you'll need to balance depth and breadth. What often works well is to create three or four paragraphs, each with its own theme.

Eg:

1. University involvement - clubs you were a part of, student council...
2. Volunteering/community work
3. Hobbies/passions

In general, activities that you dropped before university or only took up for a short time after are best left out. The second part of this essay is as important as the first. It can be helpful to think of this in terms of the "Why, What and How" of what you've chosen to devote your free time to. Why did you choose to mentor underprivileged youth? What do you get out of training for marathons, beyond "keeping fit"? How did canvassing for an electoral candidate shape your thinking and develop your skills?

A final tip here – everyone loves traveling and photography. Unless you have something truly outstanding to add about either one of these endeavors, consider showcasing interests that can set you apart.

DEADLINES & DATES

SEPTEMBER 2021 INTAKE

	APPLICATION DEADLINE	INTERVIEW INVITATIONS	FINAL DECISIONS
Round 1	11 September 2020	16 October 2020	20 November 2020
Round 2	06 November 2020	11 December 2020	22 January 2021
Round 3	08 January 2021	12 February 2021	19 March 2021
Round 4	26 February 2021	02 April 2021	07 May 2021

JANUARY 2022 INTAKE

	APPLICATION DEADLINE	INTERVIEW INVITATIONS	FINAL DECISIONS
Round 1	05 March 2020	09 April 2021	14 May 2021
Round 2	23 April 2021	28 May 2021	02 July 2021
Round 3	18 June 2021	23 July 2021	03 September 2021
Round 4	30 July 2021	27 August 2021	24 September 2021



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances of admission, reserve yours at: FortunaAdmissions.com

